



Lead roles: Women set out to make a difference in society, while fighting for equality

Reserving Right

MUNICIPAL WARDS IN MUMBAI AND GRAM PANCHAYATS IN WEST BENGAL'S BIRBHUM DISTRICT, RESERVED FOR WOMEN, WERE MORE LIKELY TO ELECT WOMEN IN SUBSEQUENT ELECTIONS THAN UNRESERVED WARDS.

women. Clearly, these people will vote for men over women, in leading positions.

One of the goals of public policy in a democracy is to ensure everyone has the opportunity for representation in all public spheres. Clearly, Indian voters have few opportunities to vote for women, and women politicians have little opportunity to prove themselves in authoritative positions.

There are strong arguments for why female under-representation in politics may have significant consequences for governance. The first relates to the power of identity. World over, citizens consider a politician's identity (be it class, gender or religion), while casting their vote because they believe a politician's identity affects his/her policy preferences. Yale Professor Ebonya Washington, for instance, has shown that in the US conditional on total number of children, each daughter increases a Congress person's propensity to vote liberally, particularly on reproductive rights issues. So, if men and women have different policy preferences then the lack of female leaders limits the political voice of half the population. A second argument relates to politician quality—if ability is equally distributed among men and women, then entry of

women into politics is likely to increase the pool of talented politicians. Studies from the US, Sweden and India suggest that not only do women and men have different policy priorities but there is no evidence proving women are worse than men in governing.

In the absence of institutional barriers, discrimination in politics may decline naturally as a result of market forces. In time, the most talented men and women will enter the political arena and as long as women govern well, voters will elect them.

But can Indian politics provide women a chance to lead and demonstrate their effectiveness? Even in the absence of institutional barriers, there remains the classic chicken and egg problem—voters who believe women are less effective will not elect them and this way women cannot lead and voters will never update their beliefs. In addition, most evidence suggests that women rarely have access to the resources, information and political networks like men do. It is arguably much harder for women to gain the party ticket of the main political parties than it is for them to enter the lower echelons of the US labour markets. Given this, a temporary policy of gender quotas in national and state